

157

Ananias of Damascus

The ordinary disciple who was sent to lay hands on the church's fiercest enemy.

Ananias was a devout believer in Damascus. Saul of Tarsus was coming to arrest people like him. Then the Lord told Ananias in a vision to go to the street called Straight and lay hands on Saul, now struck blind. Ananias was afraid, and said so. But the Lord called Saul "a chosen vessel" to carry his name to the nations. So Ananias went. His first words to the man who had come to arrest him were "Brother Saul." Scales fell from Saul's eyes, and Ananias baptized him. His obedience helped launch a great missionary.

At a glance

Name	Greek form of Hananiah, "the LORD is gracious"
Described as	"A devout man according to the law" (Acts 22:12)
When	c. AD 33–35, at Saul's conversion
Key places	Damascus; the street called Straight
Key people	Saul (Paul); the believers in Damascus
Main passages	Acts 9:10–19; 22:12–16
Not the same as	Sapphira's husband (Acts 5:1) or the high priest (Acts 23:2)

"Brother Saul, the Lord, even Jesus ... hath sent me, that thou mightest receive thy sight."

Acts 9:17, KJV

The life of Ananias of Damascus

Dates are approximate (AD). Saul's conversion is dated c. AD 33–35. Ananias's story is told twice: by Luke in Acts 9 and by Paul himself in Acts 22.

Before Saul arrives <i>Damascus</i>	● A devout disciple Ananias is a follower of Jesus living in Damascus. He is devout according to the law and well respected by the Jews there. He has heard of the harm Saul has done in Jerusalem. <i>Acts 9:10, 13; 22:12</i>
c. AD 33–35 <i>Damascus</i>	● The vision The Lord calls him by name, and Ananias answers, "Behold, I am here, Lord." He is told to go to the house of Judas on the street called Straight and ask for Saul of Tarsus, who is praying. <i>Acts 9:10–12</i>
The same vision	● Honest fear Ananias objects that Saul has come with authority to arrest all who call on Jesus' name. The Lord answers that Saul is "a chosen vessel unto me," and that he will suffer for Christ's name. <i>Acts 9:13–16</i>
The house of Judas	● Sight and baptism Ananias goes, lays his hands on Saul, and calls him "Brother Saul." Something like scales falls from Saul's eyes. He sees again, is baptized, and takes food. <i>Acts 9:17–19</i>
The house of Judas	● A message for Saul Paul later recalls that Ananias told him God had chosen him to see the Just One and be his witness to all people, and urged, "arise, and be baptized." <i>Acts 22:14–16</i>
c. AD 57 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Remembered by Paul Speaking to a hostile crowd in Jerusalem, Paul describes Ananias as a devout man with a good report among all the Jews of Damascus. <i>Acts 22:12–13</i>

Key activities

Acts names three men called Ananias: the husband of Sapphira, this disciple in Damascus, and the high priest who later tried Paul. The name was common among Jews at the time.

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- 1** **Heard and answered.** When the Lord called his name, he replied, "Behold, I am here, Lord." *Acts 9:10*
 - 2** **Spoke his fear honestly.** "Lord, I have heard by many of this man, how much evil he hath done to thy saints at Jerusalem." *Acts 9:13-14*
 - 3** **Obedied.** "And Ananias went his way, and entered into the house." *Acts 9:17*
 - 4** **Welcomed an enemy as family.** He laid hands on Saul and called him "Brother Saul." *Acts 9:17*
 - 5** **Was used to heal.** "There fell from his eyes as it had been scales: and he received sight forthwith." *Acts 9:18*
 - 6** **Baptized Saul.** He urged him, "why tarriest thou? arise, and be baptized, and wash away thy sins, calling on the name of the Lord." *Acts 9:18; 22:16*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Ananias is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: 1 Samuel 3:10	Samuel: "Speak; for thy servant heareth"
Echo: Isaiah 6:8	"Here am I; send me"
Echo: Jonah 1:1–3	Sent to people he feared, Jonah ran instead
Echo: Exodus 3:11–4:13	Moses argued with God before going

New Testament

Acts 9:10–19	Luke's account of Ananias's vision and visit.
Acts 22:12–16	Paul's own account, adding Ananias's words about his calling.
Acts 26:12–18	Paul tells the story again before King Agrippa but does not mention Ananias.
Echoes	Barnabas later did something similar in Jerusalem, taking Saul in when others were afraid of him (Acts 9:26–27). Jesus taught, "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44). Paul wrote that God's people are "fellowcitizens with the saints, and of the household of God" (Ephesians 2:19).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Ananias say to the Lord, and how did the Lord answer (Acts 9:13–16)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the words "Brother Saul" mattered so much?
3. *Apply:* Ananias admitted his fear, then obeyed. What is God asking of you that you have been putting off?
4. *Apply:* Who do you find hard to see as a brother or sister in Christ? How could you welcome them?